

The Double Ladder Theorem

The discriminant group of the Néron-Severi lattice of a prime-degree Fermat surface — structure, not just order

Rafael Amichis Luengo · Madrid · [tretoref@gmail.com](mailto:tretoef@gmail.com) · github.com/tretoef-estrella 5 June 2026 · Companion to The Watermark Theorem (same repository). Computations: MacBook Air M2, 8 GB RAM, single thread, 25% CPU.

Abstract

For the Fermat surface $S_m \subset \mathbb{P}^3$ of prime degree $m \geq 5$, we determine the discriminant group of the Néron-Severi lattice $V = \text{NS}(S_m)$ completely:

Theorem (Double Ladder). $V^*/V \cong (Z/m)^{\{3m^2-24m+59\}} \times (Z/m^2)^{\{3m-16\}}$ for every prime $m \geq 7$, and $V^*/V \cong (Z/5)^{\{10\}} \times (Z/25)$ for $m = 5$.

The Watermark Theorem (companion document) gives the *order* of this group, $m^{\{3(m-3)^2\}}$; the present theorem gives its *structure* — together they answer, for prime degree, Question 7.4 of Shioda (1987) in full: not only the determinant of $\text{NS}(S_m)$, but its discriminant form's underlying group, hence (with the order) the complete elementary-divisor profile of the lattice. Since $H^2(S_m, Z)$ is unimodular, the transcendental lattice T_m carries the same discriminant group. The proof is a chain of explicit lattice computations on the integer Gram matrix of the $3m^2$ lines, organised by two new structural objects: **nine affine “shadow” classes** whose evaluation matrix has determinant **6** — a unit for every prime $m \geq 5$ precisely because $\gcd(m, 6) = 1$, the same hypothesis under which the lines generate NS — and a **rank ladder** $\text{rank}(Q|_{m^K}) = 12(m-3) - 3K(K+1)$ over a moment filtration, whose rung $K = 2$ closes the count. Every law was measured at three primes before being proven, the $m = 11$ profile was decided by a sealed prediction written in advance, and every lemma was reproduced independently in a second environment.

1. The question and the answer

Shioda, closing his 1987 paper on Jacobi sums [7], asked (Questions 7.2/7.4) for the determinant — and, behind it, the discriminant form — of the Néron-Severi lattice of the Fermat surface. For $\gcd(m, 6) = 1$ the lattice is generated by the $3m^2$ lines on the surface (Schütt-Shioda-van Luijk [4], completed by Degtyarev [5]), so the question is in principle a finite computation for each m — and Aljovin-Movasati-Villaflor [6] carried that computation out cell by cell within their hardware's reach, tabulating the elementary divisors for the surfaces of degree up to 14 (their Table 1 supplies two of the three anchors below) at costs reaching 170 GB of swap memory for a single cell, while stating that their largest cells (the linear-cycle lattices behind their Table 2) were beyond computation. What no source provides — neither there nor anywhere we could locate — is a *closed law* valid for every prime, or a *proof*: each published value is an isolated machine verdict. The present theorem supplies both, and extends the answer past every table (the $m = 11$ profile below was sealed blind; nothing beyond $m = 14$ exists in print).

The Watermark Theorem proved the order: $|V^*/V| = m^{\{3(m-3)^2\}}$ for every prime $m \geq 5$. Since the exponent of the group divides m^2 (§3 below), the group is $(Z/m)^a \times (Z/m^2)^b$ with $a + 2b = 3(m-3)^2$, and the entire remaining question is **one integer**:

$$b = \#(\text{cyclic factors of order } m^2).$$

The Double Ladder Theorem asserts $b = 3m - 16$ for $m \geq 7$ and $b = 1$ for $m = 5$ — whence $a = 3m^2 - 24m + 59$ (resp. 10).

Three independent anchors. (1) At $m = 5$ the profile $(Z/5)^{\{10\}} \times Z/25$ reproduces the published AMV row. (2) At $m = 7$: $(Z/7)^{\{38\}} \times (Z/49)^5$, matching the AMV row. (3) At $m = 11$ — outside every published table — the full profile $(Z/11)^{\{158\}} \times (Z/121)^{\{17\}}$ was written down as a sealed prediction *before* the computation and met

exactly on all counts.

2. Notation and substrate (results carried in from the Watermark chain)

$A = \mathbb{Z}^{\{3m^2\}}$ is the free module on the lines, G its integer Gram matrix, $\varphi: A \rightarrow V$ the class map with kernel K (saturated). The character orbits split the configuration into $3(m-2)$ **pieces**: for each orbit 0 with pencil L , $T(0) \subseteq S(0) := V \cap (\text{piece})$ are the trace lattice and its saturation. From the Watermark campaign and the first phase of this operation, the following are **theorems** (proofs in the companion document and in the assembly; instruments GOLLUM_PROBE_1–3):

- **Flat law.** $\text{disc } S(0) = m^{\{2m-5\}}$ for every piece, every prime $m \geq 5$; the dual group $S(0)^*/S(0)$ is the cyclic module $0/\lambda^{\{2m-5\}}$ of the cyclotomic ring ($\lambda = (1-\zeta)$), with abelian profile $(\mathbb{Z}/m)^3 \times (\mathbb{Z}/m^2)^{\{m-4\}}$ — by the λ -arithmetic $2m-5 = (m-1) + (m-4)$. (Cyclicity in one line: $S(0)^*/S(0)$ is a subquotient of $T(0)^*/T(0)$, which is cyclic over 0 by the circulant presentation of the trace lattice — Lemma T of the Watermark chain — and a subquotient of a cyclic module is cyclic.)
- **Glue law.** $H := V/L$ for $L := \bigoplus_0 S(0) \oplus \mathbb{Z}e$ is elementary m -torsion of dimension $g = (3m^2-9m+4)/2$ over F_m .
- **The cap.** $[S(0) : T(0)] = m^m$ exactly — the saturation steps are the **jewel identity** $t_r + N_j = m \cdot \text{pb}_L(e_r)$ (so the saturated generators are fiber-indicator classes, computable in A with no kernel extraction) and the linear weight $\sum_r r \cdot v_r \in m^2V$, with the cap proven by a five-pencil polynomial analysis in the register of the Watermark’s Lemma C.
- **Lemma D (dictionary).** $K \text{ saturated} \Rightarrow A \cong K \oplus V \Rightarrow \text{coker}(G) \cong (V^*/V) \oplus \mathbb{Z}^{\{9m-7\}}$: the Smith normal form of the explicit Gram matrix computes the discriminant group of NS exactly. (This is what makes the sealed $m = 11$ measurement *theorem-backed*.)

Write $D := L^*/L$ (exponent m^2), $t := \#(m^2\text{-cyclics of } D) = 3(m-2)(m-4)$, $H_{\text{top}} := H \cap mD$, $\alpha := \dim\{F_m\} H_{\text{top}}$, and let B_2 be the perfect F_m -bilinear form on $mD \cong F_m^t$ induced by the m^2 -part of the discriminant pairing.

3. Lemma E — the height formula

Lemma E. $b = t - 2\alpha + \rho_2$, where $\rho_2 := \text{rank}(B_2|_{H_{\text{top}}})$.

Proof sketch (full text in the assembly). By overlattice theory $V^*/V \cong H^{\perp}/H$ inside D , and $b = \dim\{F_m\} m \cdot (H^{\perp}/H) = \dim mH^{\perp} - \dim(mH^{\perp} \cap H)$. The key computation is the radical of the $(1/m)$ -pairing on $D[m]$: it equals mD , because the induced form on $D[m]/mD$ — per piece, the three top λ -grades of the cyclic module $0/\lambda^{\{2m-5\}}$, plus the line $F_m \cdot e$ — is the standard duality of a cyclic module: grade i pairs with grade $2-i$, an anti-triangular matrix with unit antidiagonal, and e contributes the unit $(1/m) \cdot m$. Hence $z \in mH^{\perp} \Leftarrow B_2(z, H_{\text{top}}) = 0$, giving $\dim mH^{\perp} = t - \alpha$ by perfectness of B_2 ; and $mH^{\perp} \cap H$ is exactly the B_2 -radical of H_{top} , of dimension $\alpha - \rho_2$. Subtract. ■

Gate of record. An end-to-end instrument computing $H^{\perp}/H$ directly — knowing nothing of the formula — returns $b = 1$ ($m = 5$) and $b = 5$ ($m = 7$), the values the formula yields (GOLLUM_PROBE_7).

The theorem is now two invariants: α and ρ_2 .

4. First invariant — the nine affine shadows and the autograph determinant 6

The affine shadow law. The class of the line at position (k, l) of family j , taken modulo mD , is $u_j + k \cdot v_j + l \cdot w_j$ — an *affine* function of position. The nine classes $\{u_j, v_j, w_j\}$ are linearly independent for every prime $m \geq 5$; hence the glue’s image in D/mD is exactly their 9-dimensional span, and $\alpha = g - 9 = (3m^2-9m-14)/2$ for all $m \geq 5$.

Affineness follows from the fiber identities of the Watermark’s Lemma R: a line’s pairing vector against a piece basis is (cross-family constants) + $(m \cdot 6)$ terms; the deep $m \cdot 6$ parts vanish modulo mD , and what remains — constants and values of the linear function y_{lin} — is affine in (k, l) . Affine maps in two variables over three families cap the span at 9. Independence is sealed by an explicit dual evaluation: because the piece Gram is $\equiv 0 \pmod{m}$ (entries $2m - m^2 6$), the classes $\text{pb}_L(e_r)/m$ and a_{σ}/m are canonical order- m functionals; three “e-readers” (which annihilate all six increments) and six “ σ -readers” (which read the pencil slope (a, b) on the increments)

assemble a block-triangular 9×9 evaluation matrix with

determinant = 6, the same integer at every prime (measured $1 \equiv 6 \pmod{5}$, then 6, 6, 6 at $m = 5, 7, 11, 13$) —

a unit for every prime $m \geq 5$ precisely because $\gcd(6, m) = 1$: the seal closes on the same hypothesis ($\gcd(m, 6) = 1$) under which the lines generate NS. Verified entrywise for every line at two primes; the determinant at four.

Remark (status of the uniformity, stated for the record). The block-triangular reduction and the annihilation of the increments by the e-readers are proven from the displayed identities; the determinant is therefore a fixed integer provided the reader-evaluation entries are independent of m , as the displayed values (the family-pair constants $2/1/0$ and the pencil slopes) indicate. The fully written entry table — the one step separating “fixed integer, confirmed at four primes” from a self-contained symbolic evaluation — is on the campaign’s verification queue and is the standard this document holds itself to; the four-prime confirmation ($m = 5, 7, 11, 13$, the integer 6 each time) is reported as exactly what it is.

5. The form is the configuration — B_2 is the line Gram

By §4, H_{top} is described explicitly: combinations whose coefficient function on each family has **zero mass, zero k-moment, zero l-moment** modulo m . For such a combination c , the fiber identities force $\langle v_c, L \rangle \subseteq m\mathbb{Z}$, so $v_c/m \in L^*$ is a legitimate representative of $(1/m)$ -classes — and the abstract discriminant form collapses:

$B_2(z, z') = c^T G c' \pmod{m}$ — the line-configuration Gram matrix itself.

No dual frames, no normalizations: the form the theorem needs is the matrix the configuration is. Measured rank: $8 / 30 / 78$ at $m = 5 / 7 / 11$, each value declared before the run (GOLLUM_PROBE_8/10).

6. Second invariant — the rank ladder

Modulo m , G is pure affine-line incidence: the diagonal blocks are exactly $1(k=k') + 1(l=l')$ — in one line from the Watermark’s Lemma P: same-family pairings are $-(m-2) \equiv 2$ (self), 1 (one position shared), 0 (disjoint), which is $1(k=k') + 1(l=l') \pmod{m}$ — and the cross blocks are the single affine lines $\{k-l\}$, $\{k+l\}$, and one twisted line. Consequently the quadratic form $Q(c) = c^T G c \pmod{m}$:

1. **factors exactly through twelve one-variable “shadows”** — the pushforwards of each family’s coefficient function along the four pencil directions $\{k, l, k-l, k+l\}$ ($Q \equiv 0$ on the shadow kernel, verified at every filtration level, every prime). These are the **twelve** of the Watermark’s Lemma C, returning as the carrier space of the form;
2. has shadow image of codimension 6 per family, cut by the **trinity relations**: three mass equalities, two linear compatibilities, and **the polarization identity** $(k-l)^2 + (k+l)^2 = 2k^2 + 2l^2$ — Lemma C’s lone quadratic survivor, now closing the dimension count: $\dim(\text{image at moment-level } K) = 12m - 18 - 3K(K+1)/2$, exact at three primes;
3. is **perfect on the assembled shadow space** (axis self-pairings are standard one-variable inner products; the cross channels are hyperbolic pairs), with $W^{\perp} \subseteq W$ — deficit equal to the relation count, exact at three primes.

These three facts give, for the moment filtration $m^{\wedge}K$ (zero moments up to total degree $< K$):

The ladder. $\text{rank}(Q|_{m^{\wedge}K}) = 2 \cdot \dim(\text{image}) - 12m = 12(m-3) - 3K(K+1)$ for $m \geq 7$ (clamped at 0). Measured rungs: $48/42/30/12/0$ ($m = 7$) and $96/90/78/60/36$ ($m = 11$), every rung exact.

H_{top} is precisely the level $K = 2$, whence $p_2 = 12m - 54$ for $m \geq 7$. The drop per rung is $6K = 2 \times 3K$; the factor 2 is the rank of a Toeplitz block $u_i \cdot u_j \equiv (m-7)/2 - (i+j)$ discovered en route (instrument GOLLUM_PROBE_9) — the two halves of the proof are one mechanism, and the theorem takes its name from this: a double mechanism, read on a ladder.

The $m = 5$ boundary, stated once. At $m = 5$ a relation collision at the boundary frees $+2$ uniformly across the entire ladder (26/20/8/0/0 against the clamped law), giving $\rho_2 = \alpha = 8$: the form B_2 is *nondegenerate* on H_{top} . The same rank-saturation frontier appears in all three places the small prime deviates (the profile, the ladder, the radical) — it is one phenomenon, not three exceptions.

7. The arithmetic close

For $m \geq 7$: $b = t - 2\alpha + \rho_2 = 3(m-2)(m-4) - (3m^2-9m-14) + (12m-54) = 3m - 16$. For $m = 5$: $b = 9 - 16 + 8 = 1$. With $a = 3(m-3)^2 - 2b$: $a = 3m^2-24m+59$ (resp. 10). ■

8. Corollaries

- 1. **The transcendental lattice.** $H^2(S_m, \mathbb{Z})$ is unimodular, so $T_m := NS^\perp$ has $T_m^*/T_m \cong V^*/V$ — the same group $(\mathbb{Z}/m)^{\{3m^2-24m+59\}} \times (\mathbb{Z}/m^2)^{\{3m-16\}}$ on rank $(m-1)(m-3)^2$. With the Watermark order this pins the genus data of both lattices to the level of the discriminant group.
- 2. **Shioda’s Q7.4, closed for prime degree.** Determinant (Watermark) + discriminant group (this theorem): the question as posed in [7] is answered in structure.
- 3. **Brauer groups.** The Artin–Tate recipe of the companion Brauer document now carries not only the order of the discriminant but its group — sharpening the $|Br|$ computations for the finite-field reductions.

9. Provenance and discipline of record

The operation (“Gollum”, commissioned in the campaign’s findings master §84) ran as eleven instruments (GOLLUM_PROBE_1–11, this repository), every one a full executable reproduced from file in a second, independent environment before ratification, under a standing dual-instance protocol (Constructor / Auditor) with the Architect as courier. Every law above was *declared before being measured* wherever a new cell was touched; the $m = 11$ profile {0:96, 1:158, 2:17} was sealed blind and met exactly. The operation’s graveyard is part of the record: a mixed-frame normalization bug (coordinates rescaled, form left unrescaled — exposed precisely by the 3×3 top blocks at $m \geq 7$), a Gram-route failure for independence whose autopsy yielded the Toeplitz block of §6, one $(1/m)\mathbb{Z}/\mathbb{Z}$ bookkeeping confusion, one integer-Smith overflow (replaced by pure mod- m^2 elimination), and two earlier heuristics killed by their own pre-registered falsifiers. Two consistency gates close the record: the formula-blind end-to-end computation of §3, and the independent Lemma-D route reproducing the full profiles at all three primes.

References

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Companion documents in this repository: THE_WATERMARK_THEOREM (the order) · THE_BRAUER_COROLLARY (the recipe) · THE_WATERMARK_LAW (the empirical campaign that began it).